



The 8 Secrets Of Successful Entrepreneurs



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35+ years. 20,000+ successful entrepreneurs.

Here's what we've learned.

Most entrepreneurs start with a vision of freedom—of more time, more income, and more impact. Yet somewhere along the way, that vision gets buried under the ever-growing weight of daily responsibilities.

The late nights. The endless to-dos. The weekends sacrificed. The constant decisions. The days spent putting out fires. The nagging feeling that progress isn't happening fast enough.

The reality is, if you've reached this stage, then your business might be running *you* instead of the other way around.

But you're not alone. Many of the most driven entrepreneurs find themselves stuck at their current level of success. Yet while your drive is what got you here, it's *not* what will get you to the next level.

The reality is, all ambitious entrepreneurs hit a turning point where working harder simply isn't enough to reach the next stage of growth.

The good news? There's a better way.

A way to scale your business without the burnout. A way to grow beyond your current limits without just having to do more. And a way to achieve the freedom and impact you envisioned from the start—without sacrificing everything else.

After working with more than 20,000 entrepreneurs over the last 35+ years at Strategic Coach®, we've seen exactly what separates those who stay stuck from those who break through to achieve incredible success in both business *and* life.

This guide explores those differences by revealing the **eight time-tested success secrets** we've seen consistently set high-achieving entrepreneurs apart. These principles aren't just marketing "hacks" or ways to make you more money—they're about redefining your approach to entrepreneurship so you can reclaim the growth and freedom you originally set out to create.

Let's dig in.

How To Get The Most Out Of This Guide

After each success secret, you'll find a quick self-assessment prompt. Rate yourself on a scale of 1 to 10, to see how effectively you're currently applying each principle:

1 = Needs significant improvement

10 = Already excelling and confident in this area

If you come across an area where you want to improve, you'll find immediate, actionable recommendations right below your score that are designed to help you level up quickly.

When you reach the end of this guide, review your scores for all eight success secrets, and:

1. Note any key insights that came up while completing this exercise.
2. List action steps or priorities you want to tackle moving forward.

By taking just a few moments to evaluate your current progress and follow the provided recommendations, you'll gain a solid road map for sustainable, ongoing growth—in revenue, free time, impact, relationships, or just about anything else you're aiming for.

Successful Entrepreneur Secret #1:

Above all else, start with your vision.

One of the biggest secrets to success according to Strategic Coach® co-founder and world-renowned entrepreneur Dan Sullivan is simple: vision. Dan's vision has carried him through a 60-year entrepreneurial journey—helping him stay on track despite setbacks like divorce and bankruptcy—and it's the driving force behind the success of Strategic Coach.

That's why, though so many entrepreneurs are tempted to dive straight into action, we always recommend taking the time to clarify your vision first. After all, your vision is the compass that guides you through the difficult days and ensures that you focus on what truly matters rather than getting lost in the daily grind.

Most importantly, your vision is a reminder of why you became an entrepreneur in the first place: not just to grow your business, but to build one that supports the lifestyle and freedom you're looking for.

Score yourself on this success secret: From 1-10, how clear are you on the future vision you have for your business and life?

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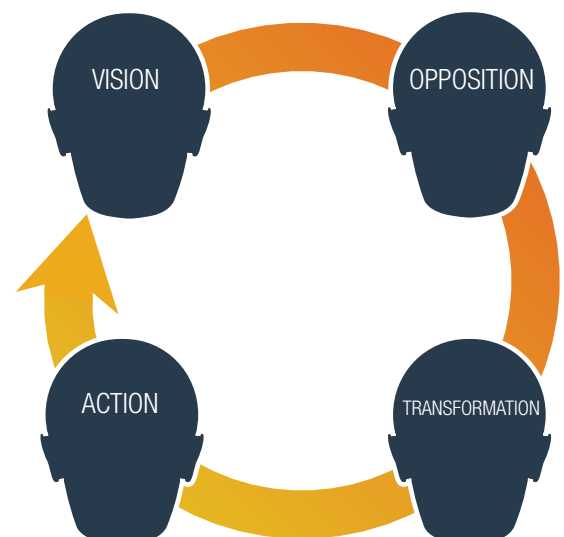
See some room for improvement? Try The VOTA Formula™.

At Strategic Coach, we take visioning very seriously. So much so that we've created a specific process called The VOTA Formula, which is a unique thinking-and-action framework that leverages four innate human abilities:

- 1. Vision:** The ability to imagine and commit to future results that don't yet exist.
- 2. Opposition:** The ability to see all the obstacles that could prevent the future results.
- 3. Transformation:** The ability to transform the obstacles into strategies.
- 4. Action:** The ability to implement those strategies to achieve the results.

To try it yourself, begin by reflecting on your current vision for your business and life (feel free to use the "Insights & Actions" worksheet at the end of this guide).

Use The VOTA Formula to articulate what your ideal future looks like, recognize the obstacles that could get in your way, and outline the actions needed to move toward that future.



Successful Entrepreneur Secret #2:

Think bigger for easier and more exponential growth.

When asked what it would take to 10x their business, many assume it would mean working 10x harder—such as clocking in 80-hour weeks, bringing their laptop on every family vacation, or eliminating all personal activities that don't directly drive business ROI.

While that was once the standard assumption in entrepreneurship (and still is in many circles!), here's the truth: 10x growth isn't about doing more; it's about doing things *differently*.

It's about focusing on building the right team, refining your systems, and implementing strategies that deliver a 10x payoff—whether in free time, productivity, profitability, or whatever else matters most to you.

And after watching more than 20,000 entrepreneurs achieve exponential growth over the past 35+ years, we'd even go so far as to boldly claim the following: growing 10x is actually *easier* than merely growing 2x.

After all, a 2x increase relies on simply doing *more* of what you're already doing, which just isn't sustainable in the long term if you're already tapped out.

Reaching for 10x growth, on the other hand, requires a completely new paradigm. It demands a radical shift in how you approach decision making, set priorities, and manage your energy. It means working smarter, transforming your operations, and reimagining the business so you're freed up to focus on what you do best: innovating and providing visionary leadership.

Envisioning a 10x future reveals new possibilities. It forces you to take a fresh look at how you currently operate and identify what needs to change *today* to support future growth.

By making this type of expansive thinking a daily habit, you can begin to spot and seize opportunities for exponential progress. And before long, thinking 10x bigger will become a natural part of your routine.

Score yourself on this success secret: From 1-10, how often do you challenge yourself to think 10x bigger rather than simply working harder?

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See some room for improvement? Grab your copy of Dan Sullivan and Dr. Benjamin Hardy's book [*10x Is Easier Than 2x: How World-Class Entrepreneurs Achieve More By Doing Less*](#).

Alternatively, try asking yourself:

- *What in my life and business supports 10x growth?*
- *What in my life doesn't support 10x growth?*
- *What's missing in both my life and business that could help me go 10x?*
- *What's present in both my life and business that I could take advantage of to go 10x?*

Successful Entrepreneur Secret #3:

Maximize your entrepreneurial impact with Dan Sullivan's favorite thinking tool, The Impact Filter™.

As Dan Sullivan is quick to point out, almost all the trouble you'll get yourself into as an entrepreneur comes down to one thing: trying to sell something (whether a new idea to your clients or a new project to your team) that you're not sold on yourself.

That's why, before anyone on our team gets involved in *anything* new—and we really do mean anything, from a new project or workshop to a marketing event, speech, interview, or client meeting—we fill out Dan Sullivan's #1 thinking tool: The Impact Filter™.

The Impact Filter is designed to get you highly focused on the result you want to see (i.e., the impact you want to have) and to sell yourself on every project or idea you're involved in *before* taking action.

As Dan describes it, filling out an Impact Filter is a quick and simple way to multiply the result and impact of every project you take on.

Score yourself on this success secret: From 1-10, before starting a new project or meeting, do you take time to clarify the result and impact you want and why it matters?



See some room for improvement? Get [The Impact Filter](#) 100% for free here.

For best results, never start another project—or host another meeting—without The Impact Filter.

Successful Entrepreneur Secret #4:

Measure your success from where you started, not where you're trying to go.

Do you find that, no matter how much success you achieve, you're still dissatisfied with your progress? Or perhaps you feel that, despite all your hard work, your biggest goals remain out of reach?

The reality is that most entrepreneurs struggle to appreciate their achievements—though few realize just how much this lack of recognition gets in the way of breakthroughs and reduces their satisfaction in both business and life.

At Strategic Coach, we call this condition “being in The Gap.”

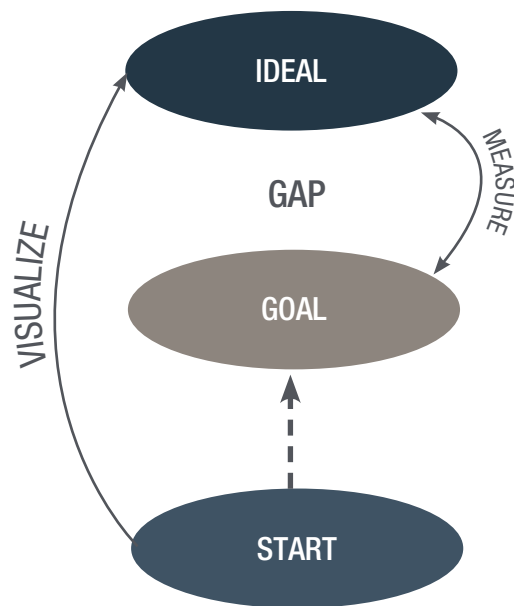
We see an astonishing number of high-performing entrepreneurs fall into this trap, driven by a false belief that the issue is the quantity or quality of their successes. However, the truth is that it's actually an issue of *how* they measure them.

Entrepreneurs stuck in The Gap constantly look forward and measure themselves against an ideal they'll likely never achieve. Even when significant progress is made, they can't help but remain unsatisfied because they focus on how far they still have to go.

A better alternative? Striving to spend your time “living in The Gain.”

Unlike being in The Gap, living in The Gain means looking back and measuring success from where you started. Even if you haven't yet reached your ultimate goal, The Gain gives you a way to recognize your progress, ultimately boosting your confidence, energy, and satisfaction.

Many entrepreneurs we teach this system to describe it as “flipping a switch in your brain.” When you live in The Gain, success can instantly become something you continuously achieve—rather than something that always seems just out of reach.



Score yourself on this success secret: From 1-10, how frequently do you measure your progress based on how far you've come rather than how far you have left to go?

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See some room for improvement? Read [*The Gap And The Gain: The High Achievers' Guide To Happiness, Confidence, and Success*](#) by Dan Sullivan and Dr. Benjamin Hardy.

Be on the lookout for times when you start measuring your success against an ideal (watch for words like “could,” “should,” and “would”)—and then stop doing it!

Successful Entrepreneur Secret #5:

Follow internal desires, not external benchmarks.

The business world is divided into two types of entrepreneurs: those who operate from a scarcity mindset and those who embrace abundance.

Entrepreneurs driven by a scarcity mindset often find themselves chasing what they believe they “need” to gain external validation, security, and a competitive edge in a world of limited resources. As a result, these individuals frequently spend their days justifying these “needs”—not only to themselves but to everyone around them.

In contrast, today’s most innovative entrepreneurs aren’t held back by demands for justification or a mindset of “needing.” Rather, they’ve cultivated a mindset of “wanting” that allows them to set ambitious goals and pursue them without feeling the obligation to rationalize or apologize. Driven by unshakable internal desires, wanting something is all the justification they need.

This fundamental shift from external “needing” to internal “wanting” can not only offer a personal transformation, it can also revolutionize your approach to both business and life.

The world’s top 1% of entrepreneurs operate unapologetically, fueled by internal motivations and confidence in a landscape of growing abundance that allows them to continually create bigger and better futures for themselves and others. Who’s to say you can’t do the same?

Score yourself on this success secret: From 1-10, do you make decisions based on your internal desires rather than external benchmarks?



See some room for improvement? Begin the shift from an externally-driven “needing” mindset to an internally-driven “wanting” mindset by focusing on overcoming your need for justification.

This can best be done by practicing standing firm in your wants and asking yourself: *What do I really want in my business? Is that currently being driven by internal desires or external benchmarks? What might it look like if I shifted my focus from external motivators to internal ones?*

Successful Entrepreneur Secret #6:

Consistently increase your confidence and capabilities by mastering The 4 C's Formula®.

How often do you find yourself stuck in “getting ready” mode—without ever taking that next leap? If you're nodding your head, then you're in good company.

The truth is that many entrepreneurs remain on the sidelines, waiting for confidence or capability to magically appear before they feel “ready” to commit to their next steps. Here's what you need to know: the confidence and capability you're waiting on to magically appear? Those only come *after* you commit.

We've observed a consistent, four-step process that takes place before each breakthrough. And perhaps unexpectedly, that process *starts* with commitment. We call it The 4 C's Formula®, and it's a universal process that anyone can use to reach that next level of success in any area of life or business. Here's how it works.

Step 1: Commitment

First, you have to take a leap of faith and commit to whatever it is you want to achieve—even if you don't yet feel ready or if it frightens you.

Step 2: Courage

From there, you need to take a good, hard look at the areas of fear, uncertainty, and discomfort that stand in the way of your vision. This step can be uncomfortable, especially since you've likely committed yourself to something long before feeling fully capable.

Step 3: Capability

By sticking with your commitment and finding the courage to move forward despite your fears, you'll begin taking the action steps needed to develop new capabilities in yourself—eventually building up to the full capabilities required for your breakthrough.

Step 4: Confidence

Your reward for pushing through the first three stages is a new level of confidence, which then opens the door for you to be able to commit to an even bigger breakthrough.



Score yourself on this success secret: From 1-10, when faced with a new challenge or goal, how well do you commit first and trust that confidence will follow?



See some room for improvement? Remember, everything starts with commitment.

Commitment then creates courage, courage creates capability, capability creates confidence, and confidence creates more commitment (which in turn creates more breakthroughs!).

And if you'd also like to commit to giving your business the best possible future—plus get insight into your best next steps for growth—[consider joining our team for a complimentary 1:1 Discovery Call.](#)

Successful Entrepreneur Secret #7:

Fix procrastination with The 80% Approach™.

There's one consistent pattern that separates successful entrepreneurs from those who struggle: their relationship with perfectionism.

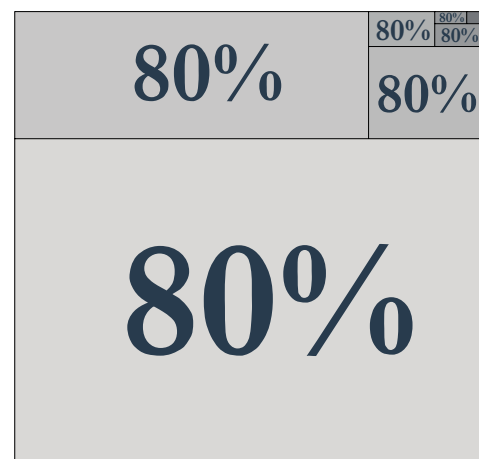
The reality is that many entrepreneurs are paralyzed by their need for perfection. This, in turn, triggers spirals of procrastination that lead to missed opportunities and an inability to move forward on revenue-generating projects that could truly level up their businesses.

That's why, here at Strategic Coach, we've identified a simple approach that has helped thousands of entrepreneurs break free from the traps of procrastination and perfectionism: The 80% Approach.

The Power Of The First 80%

Successful entrepreneurs understand that their role isn't to perfect every detail but to ideate, create, and provide crystal-clear direction. As a leader, this means simply "making it up" to the 80% mark—that is, quickly putting together a solid foundation and vision that trusted team members can then execute.

After all, we've never seen anyone fail because they acted on 80% readiness. However, we *have* seen countless opportunities slip away while an entrepreneur waited for 100% readiness that was unlikely to ever arrive.



The Hand-Off

Once the initial 80% is complete, the next step is to let others execute. By releasing the need for perfection and delegating to skilled project managers or team members, you'll be able to see your long-standing ideas transformed into reality—*without* procrastination paralysis getting in the way.

The Multiplication Effect

The true power of The 80% Approach™ is its scalability. By applying the 80% rule repeatedly—completing the bulk of the work and delegating the remainder—you and your team can create recurring processes that drive scalable, exponential growth.

Score yourself on this success secret: From 1-10, do you embrace progress over perfection by getting ideas 80% done and delegating the rest?

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See some room for improvement? Take out a notebook and list every project that's currently stalled because you're waiting for perfection.

Choose one project, complete the first 80%, and then confidently hand it off to your team with clear directions. Finally, watch what happens when you let go of that need for perfection, and notice how the project gets done in a way you could have never accomplished alone (if you ever finished it at all).

Successful Entrepreneur Secret #8:

Stop asking “**How?**” and start asking “**Who?**”

Have you ever had a new idea or goal that excited you but simply couldn't find enough time to execute on it? Or do you ever find yourself trying to prioritize working on the things that really matter, but instead get stuck spending your time on the daily minutiae of running the business?

For many entrepreneurs, these challenges are all too common. Often, this happens because we're trained to ask, “*How can I do this?*” However, the question we really should be asking is, “*Who can do this for me?*”

The question at the heart of this framework—and the core of Dan Sullivan and Strategic Coach's Who Not How™ philosophy—may seem simple, but don't let that fool you. Put simply, finding the “Whos” to accomplish your “Hows” is the secret to powering your business to that next level—something that both Dan Sullivan as well as the thousands of other entrepreneurs who have used the philosophy to build incredible burnout-free businesses and guilt-free personal freedom can attest to!

In the famous words of Harry S. Truman, “*It is amazing what you can accomplish if you do not care who gets the credit.*”

Score yourself on this success secret: From 1-10, do you focus on finding the right people to help you achieve your biggest goals instead of getting held back trying to do everything yourself?

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See some room for improvement? Join the 200,000+ ambitious entrepreneurs who've already grabbed their copy of the bestselling book [*Who Not How: The Formula To Achieve Bigger Goals Through Accelerating Teamwork*](#) by Dan Sullivan and Dr. Benjamin Hardy.

Alternatively, try this exercise: Write down three to five big goals for your business or life. Then, instead of asking *how* you'll achieve them, try asking *who* can help you achieve them instead.

Insights & Actions

What did you learn from this guide?

My Top 3 Action Steps

What are the first three actions or priorities you want to tackle moving forward?

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What's Next?

Now that you've worked your way through this guide, we need to be honest about something: simply learning the *theory* behind these strategies, frameworks, and mindsets will only take you so far.

The true power lies in being able to bring them to life alongside the support of an ambitious, like-minded community that “gets it” ...

The guidance of experienced entrepreneurial coaches who have already mastered these eight entrepreneurial success secrets in their own businesses ...

Plus a dedicated, growth-focused space to think, plan, and execute without getting caught up in the daily business grind.

And that's exactly what you get when you become a member of Strategic Coach.

As you may have noticed while reading this guide, we're not here to offer cookie-cutter marketing tactics or “growth hacks.” Nor are we here to tell you what to do. After all, most entrepreneurs already know how to grow a business. What we're here to do is give you the missing pieces you need to grow to that next level.

That's why, when you join Strategic Coach, you'll get:

- A proven yet customizable framework for achieving the growth you're looking for—whether in revenue, free time, impact, relationships, teamwork, or anything else.
- Clear insights and a fresh perspective to help you tackle your biggest challenges and determine your most impactful next steps.
- A supportive community of like-minded entrepreneurs who understand your journey.
- Ongoing coaching and accountability that keeps you on track every step of the way.
- Tangible results and growth that allow you to achieve more while increasing your freedom.

To find out if Strategic Coach could be the right partner in getting you to that next level, visit our website at www.strategiccoach.com.